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Password Protection Policy

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Enacted

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1. Objective

The purpose of this policy is to establish a standard for the secure use and protection of all work related passwords. Passwords are a critical aspect of computer security. A weak or compromised password can result in unauthorized access to our most sensitive data and/or exploitation of our resources. All staff, including consultants, volunteers, and others with access to Partners databases, or systems, are responsible for taking the appropriate steps, as outlined below, to select and secure their passwords

2. Policy

Partners expects that all Partners staff, consultants, volunteers, and others with access to Partners systems adhered to the following password requirements.

2.1 Password Creation and Use

1. All user-level and system-level passwords must conform to the [Password Construction Guidelines](#).
2. Users must use a separate, unique password for each of their work related accounts.
3. Staff are allowed to use authorized, approved password managers to securely store and manage all their work related passwords.
4. Multi-factor authentication is highly encouraged and should be used whenever possible.

2.1.1 Password Construction Guidelines

These guideline applies to all passwords including but not limited to user-level accounts, system-level accounts, web accounts, e-mail accounts, screen saver protection, voicemail, and other logins. Strong passwords are long, the more characters, the stronger the password. Partners recommends the following:

- **Complexity Requirements:** Passwords must be a minimum length of 12 characters, comprising a mix of uppercase and lowercase letters, numbers, and special characters.
- **Use of Passphrases:** Passphrases passwords are made up of multiple words. Examples include “It’s time for vacation” or “block-curious-street-leaves”. Passphrases are both easy to remember and type yet meet the strength requirements.
- **Avoidance of Common Patterns:** Prohibit the use of easily guessable patterns, such as sequential numbers or commonly used phrases.

2.2 Password Changes

Passwords should be changed at least every 160 days or when there is reason to believe a password has been compromised or fails to meet the minimum password requirements.



2.3 Password Protection - Access and Usage

1. Passwords must not be shared with anyone, including supervisors and coworkers, unless it is a shared account and authorization has been to share the password.
2. All passwords are to be treated as sensitive and confidential information.
3. Passwords must not be inserted into email messages, nor revealed over the phone to anyone.
4. Passwords may be stored only in password managers approved by Partners Chief Operating Officer (COO).
5. Implement an automated account lockout mechanism after a specified number of unsuccessful login attempts to prevent brute force attacks.
6. Any individual suspecting that their password may have been compromised must change all relevant passwords.
7. Passwords should not be stored in unencrypted documents or shared them through insecure communication channels.